D-FREE FOUNDATION

D-FREE FOUNDATION

NEWSLETTER



Introduction:

Welcome to the very first issue of the D-FREE Newsletter! Our mission is to fight diarrheal disease, one of the leading causes of child mortality in Rwanda and Sub-Saharan Africa. This newsletter will keep you updated on our milestones, share inspiring stories from the field, and highlight the amazing partnerships that make this work possible.

About the D-Free Project

The D-Free Project is a youth-led and community-driven initiative that aims to prevent diarrheal disease in Rwanda, one of the leading causes of child mortality in the world. Our work focuses on WASH (Water, Sanitation, and Hygiene), public health education, nutrition and child health, and community empowerment. By combining practical interventions such as clean water provision, toilet renovation, and ORS distribution with capacity building for students and Community Health Workers, the project delivers both immediate impact and long-term resilience in vulnerable communities in Rwanda.



d.free_official

d43098182@gmail.com





Project Highlights: Gisagara District

From our last chapter in Gisagara District, we witnessed firsthand what community-led health work looks like in action. Over several days, our team, together with MEDSAR volunteers and local Community Health Workers, led interactive training sessions for 20 participants, including CHWs and medical students. The team also organized three village assemblies to engage families, demonstrated proper handwashing techniques and water filter use, and supported households in improving their sanitation conditions. By the close of the final session, 15 homes had upgraded latrines, and 10 families received household water filters, marking a tangible step toward cleaner, healthier living environments in the community.

Successful Outcome:
Transforming Community Health in Gisagara District

The launch of the D-FREE Project in Gisagara District marked a turning point for 112 families working toward better health and sanitation. During the launch event, medical students, Community Health Workers (CHWs), and local leaders came together to educate families on hygiene practices, clean water use, and the dangers of diarrheal disease.

Through collaboration with the Health Center Director, village leaders, and CHWs, the project reached households with children under five, one of the most vulnerable groups. Originally planned for 100 families, the project expanded to include 12 additional households who requested to join after hearing about the initiative. This showed strong community interest and trust in the program.

From this launch, we provided families with practical knowledge and support to make real changes at home. Parents learned about the importance of handwashing and safe water consumption, while children were encouraged to develop healthy daily habits.

Overall, this event showed how community engagement can turn awareness into action. Families are now more informed, CHWs have gained new skills, and students experienced what it means to deliver care at the community level. The success in Gisagara District reflects D-FREE's ongoing mission to build healthier and more resilient communities, one household at a time.

D-FREE FOUNDATION



Upcoming Chapter: Musanze District

Based on vulnerability mapping and on-the-ground assessments, we identified Musanze District as the most critical next focus area, where water access gaps and the burden of diarrheal disease call for urgent action. Moving forward, we aim to deepen our partnerships with district health authorities in Musanze to strengthen the local health system's response. This next phase will focus on expanding resource allocation for additional household water filters and latrine upgrades, empowering community-led monitoring teams, and developing a reporting framework to ensure that every new village can replicate the success achieved in Gishya.

Community Voices from Gisagara District

As the D-FREE Project continues to grow, the most powerful proof of the impacts comes from the people themselves. Here are some reflections from those who have witnessed real change in their homes and communities:







Village Leader:
"Thanks to your commitment, our village now boasts 15 modern toilets and clean water for 10 families. We've embraced your teachings and aim to be the first diarrhea-free village in the district."

Community Health Worker:
"This project perfectly complements our role. Educating people on prevention and providing materials empowers us to keep diarrhea at bay."

Project Beneficiary:
"Our children used to drink swamp water. With these filters, they now drink safely. I feel peace of mind every time they fill their cups."

Another Beneficiary:
"My old toilet was roofless. Now, with an iron-sheet roof and a hand-washing station, my family's daily routine includes hygiene steps we never knew before."

Looking Ahead: D-FREE's Mission in Musanze

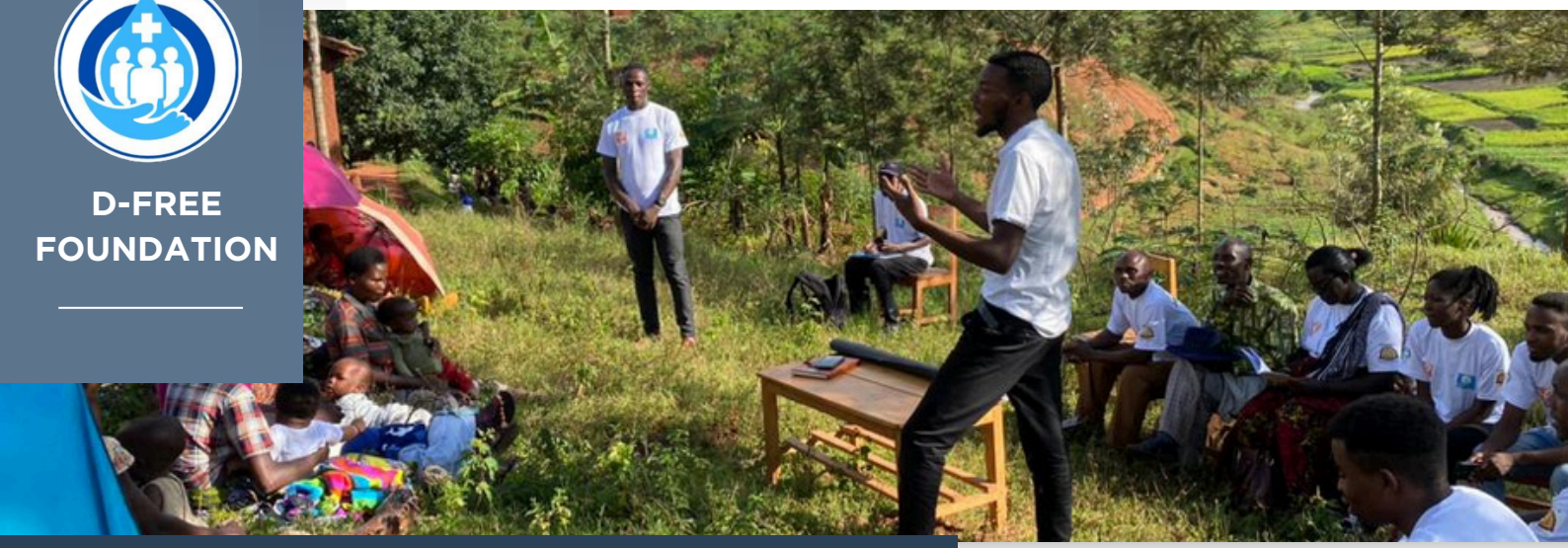
The D-FREE Project's upcoming activities in Musanze will prioritize vulnerable families living under poor sanitation conditions. These include household outreach to identify families with children under five, water and hygiene support through the distribution of filters and treatment tablets, and health interventions such as providing ORS and zinc supplements to address diarrhea and malnutrition. Capacity-building efforts will train caregivers and CHWs in hygiene practices and disease prevention, while community workshops will engage parents and children in creating long-term behavior change. With Musanze as our new focus, D-FREE is committed to scaling its impact beyond Gisagara and helping more children grow up healthy, safe, and free from preventable diarrheal diseases.



d.free_official

d43098182@gmail.com

D-FREE FOUNDATION



Voices from the D-Free Project Team

Behind every step of the D-FREE Project is a dedicated group of students and volunteers who bring their passion, expertise, and compassion to the field. Here's what some of our team members have learned and why this project matters to them.



Brian Shihyoung Lee, Intervention Team:
"Through the D-Free Project, I've realized how urgent it is to address diarrheal disease and how medical interventions can make a real impact. I'm passionate about nutritional science and biochemistry, especially the gut microbiome, which is deeply connected to diarrheal treatment."



Aiden Seunghu Lee, Hygiene Product Team:
"I've learned how small hygiene tools such as soap and clean water filters can prevent diarrhea and how teamwork makes these ideas succeed. Having faced digestive health issues myself, I care about gut health and see this as a chance to learn about global health while helping others."



Kris Yoon, Education & Marketing Team:
"Through the D-FREE Project, I've learned just how severe diarrheal disease is among young children around the world, and how education can truly change that reality. By spreading awareness and promoting simple hygiene practices, we empower families to take control of their health. Being part of the education and marketing team has shown me the power of communication in driving lasting community impact."



Yoonchae Kayla Lee, Administration& Intervention Team:
"I learned how D-Free's hygiene initiatives directly improve people's daily lives in Rwanda by helping communities prevent diarrheal diseases through better sanitation practices. Seeing how simple implementations, like handwashing stations and hygiene education, can make such a difference has shown me the real impact of public health work. This experience has helped me understand how coordinated efforts and local engagement can create long-term improvements in community well-being as being part of the administration team."

Partnership & Collaboration

The D-FREE Project is proud to be supported by strong partnerships that strengthen its mission and sustainability. MEDSAR, the Medical Students' Association of Rwanda, plays a key role in mobilizing youth volunteers and nurturing future health leaders, while the Government of Rwanda through the Ministry of Health provides institutional support and ensures the project aligns with national health priorities. Together, these collaborations form the foundation of D-FREE's success and ensure that it continues to grow as a movement dedicated to building a healthier Rwanda.

Call to Action: Join Us in Creating a Healthier Future

Follow Our Journey:
Stay updated by following our official Instagram page @**d.free_official** for stories from the field, project highlights, and educational content!

Volunteer With Us:
We welcome dedicated medical students, Community Health Workers, and young professionals who want to support hygiene education and field outreach.

Support Families in Need:
Your contribution can provide hygiene kits, water filters, and essential health supplies to vulnerable households. Sponsorships and donations help us reach more communities.

Spread the Word:
Share our mission with your friends, colleagues, and networks. Increasing awareness is one of the most powerful tools we have in preventing diarrheal disease.





d.free_official

d43098182@gmail.com